Unit 3

Six-Eight Time

New: 6/8: two beats in a bar, each beat split into three eighths

In 6/8 time a bar holds six eighth notes, grouped in two sets of three: ONE two three FOUR five six. At a slow speed you can count all six. At a normal speed you feel only two beats in a bar, and each beat splits into three. That gives 6/8 its rocking, swinging feel, like a boat song or a lullaby.

What is new

6/8

The bottom 8 means the eighth note is the counting unit, and the top 6 means six of them in a bar. Eighths are beamed in threes, so you can see the two beats.

The beat is a dotted quarter

One beat in 6/8 lasts three eighths: a dotted quarter note. A dotted half note fills the whole bar. The metronome marks in this unit count dotted quarters.

Long-short

A quarter note followed by an eighth (counted 1-2 3) is the typical 6/8 rhythm: long, short, long, short. Do not let it turn into an even pair.

Two new bass patterns

Lilting: bottom (quarter), top (eighth), middle (quarter), top (eighth). Rolling: six eighths, bottom, middle, top, middle, top, middle.

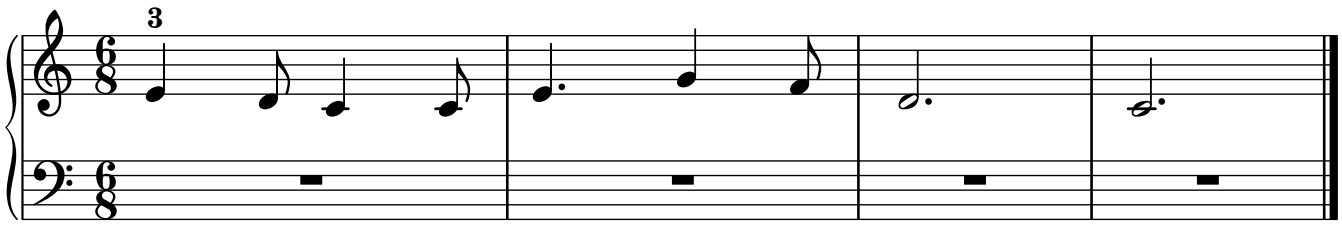
Reading tips

1. Count six slowly first, then switch to two beats: ONE-and-a TWO-and-a.
2. Find the dotted quarters and dotted halves before you start: they show where the beats are.
3. Feel the long-short swing in the left hand, and let the right hand ride on it.

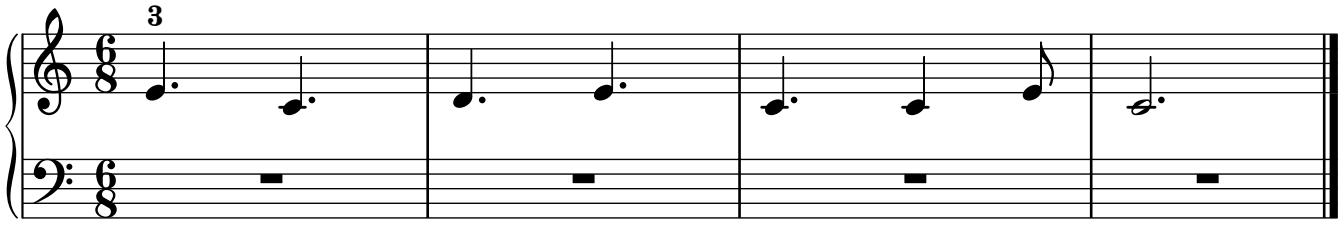
Part A: Two beats in a bar ♩. = 50

Right hand in C position. Count six eighths at first; the metronome gives one click per dotted quarter.
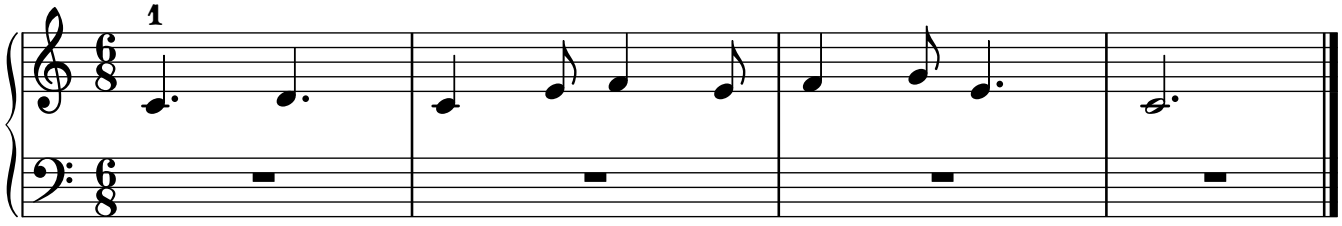
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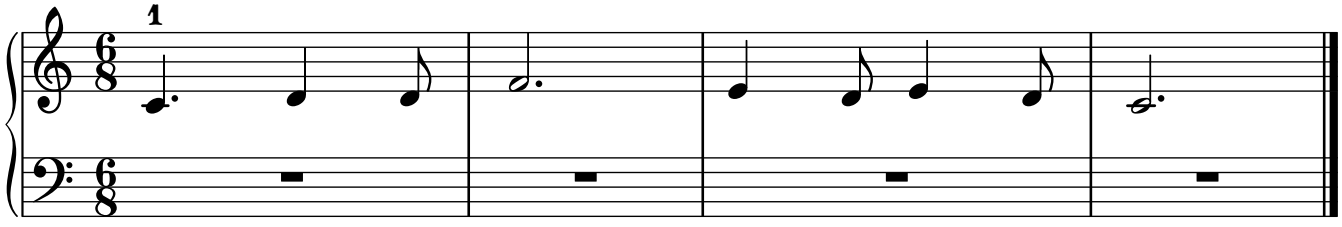
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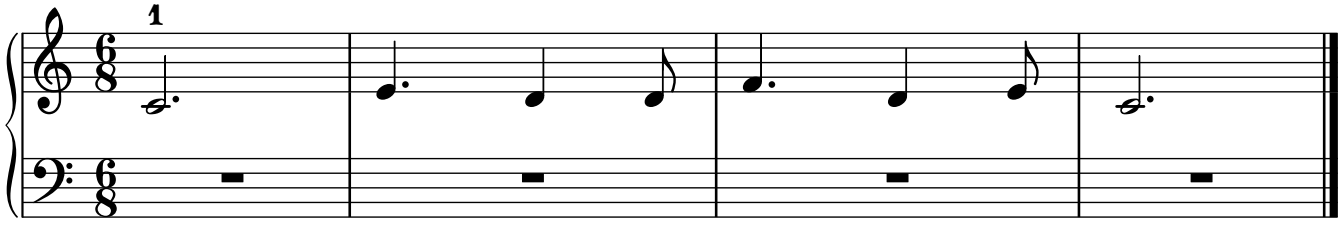
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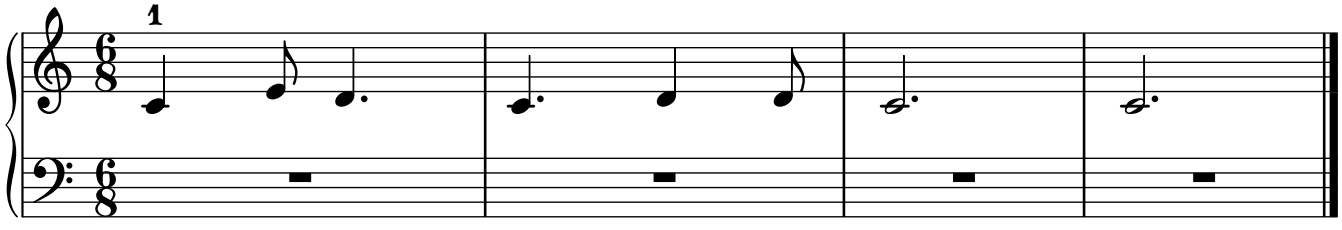
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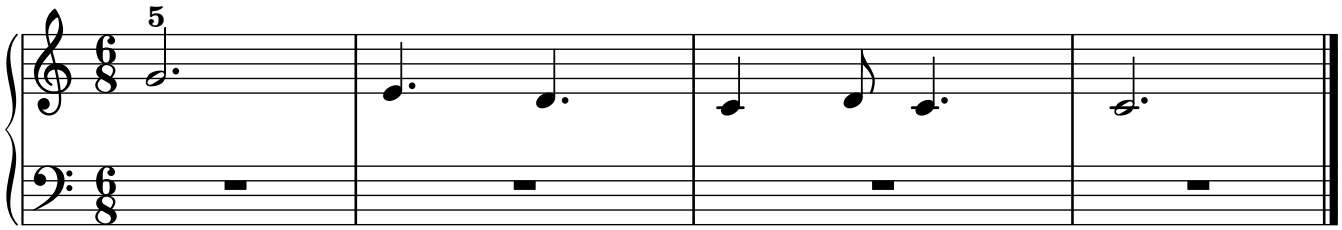
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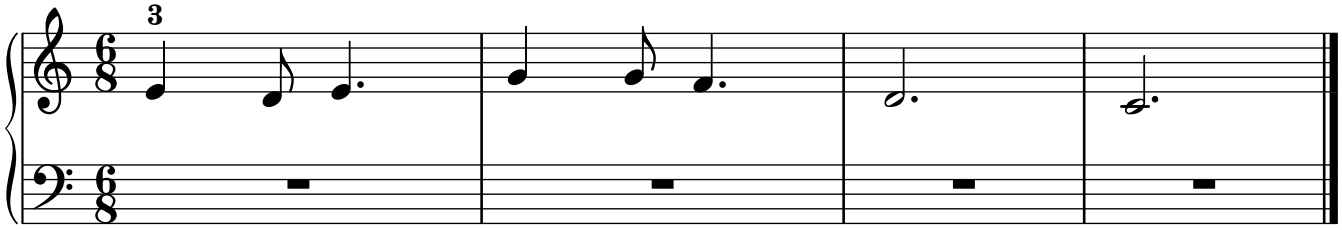
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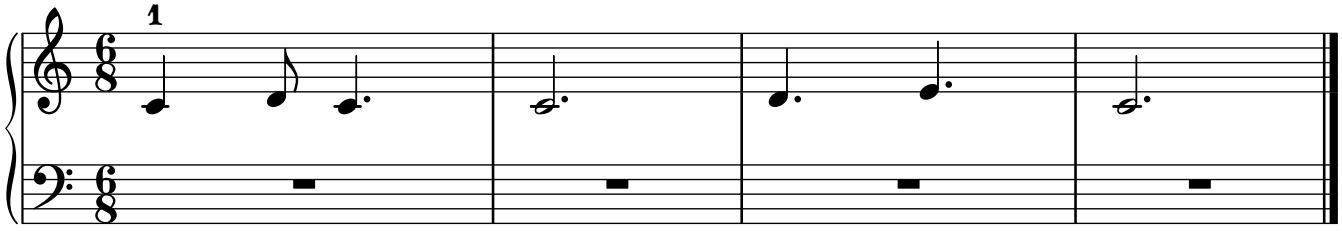
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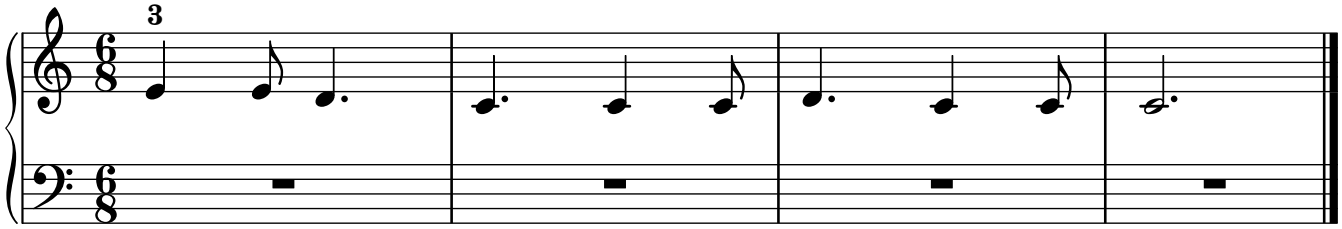
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☐ **3.9**
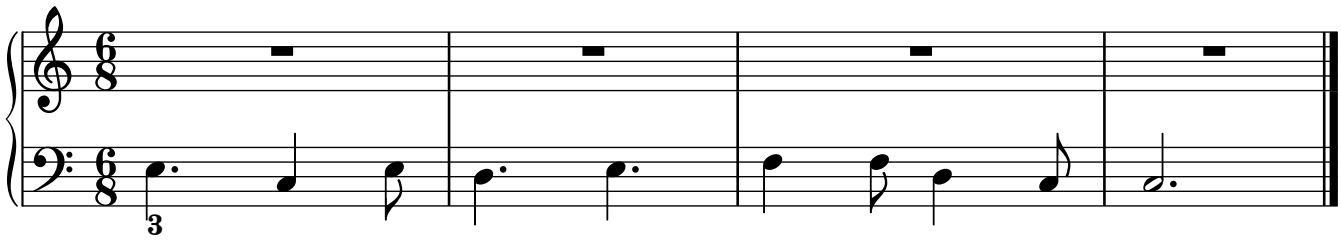


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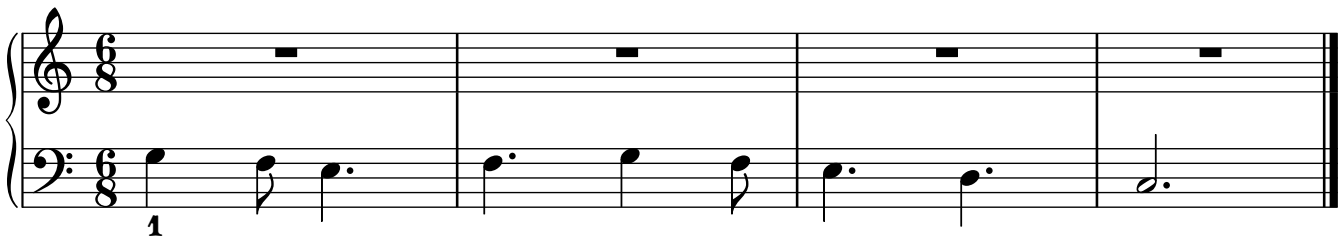
Part B: 6/8 in the left hand ♩. = 50

Left hand in C position, in 6/8.

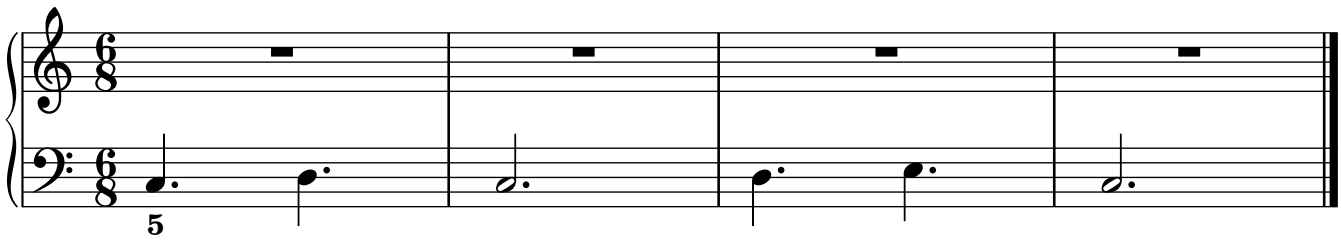
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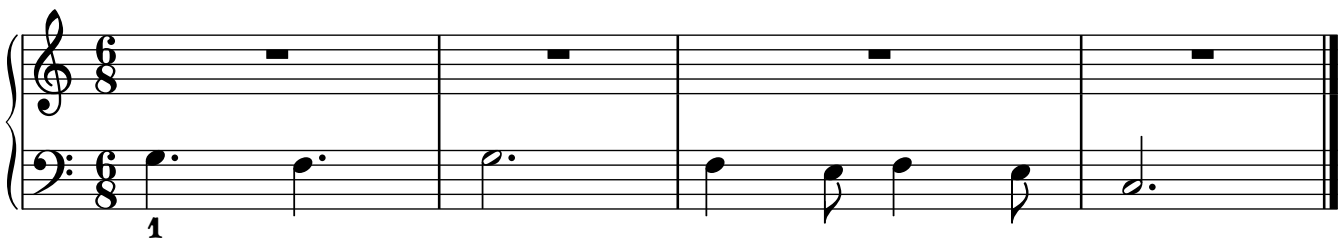
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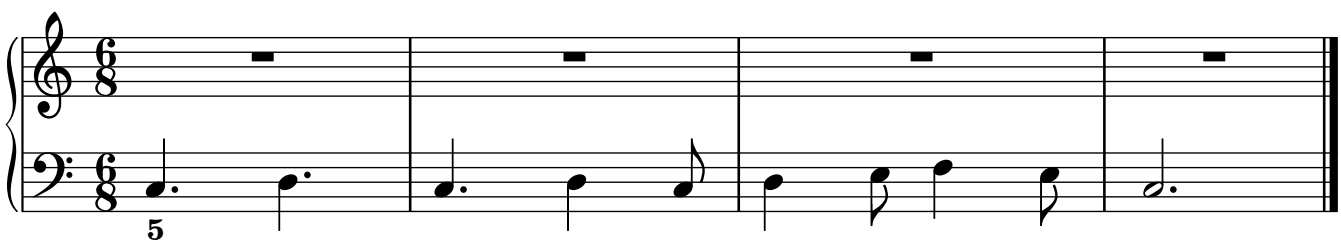


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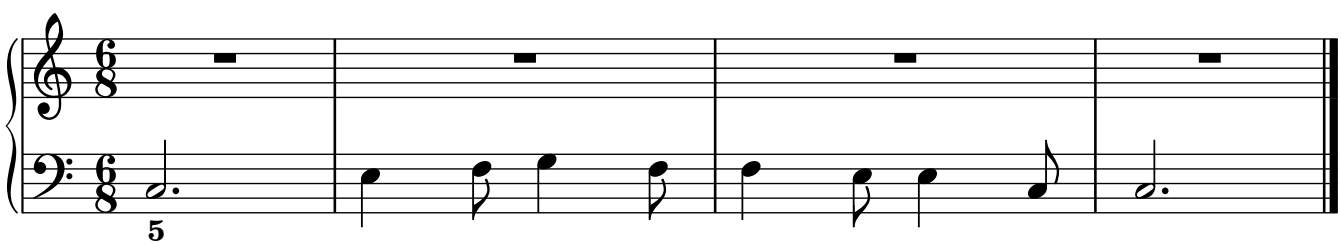
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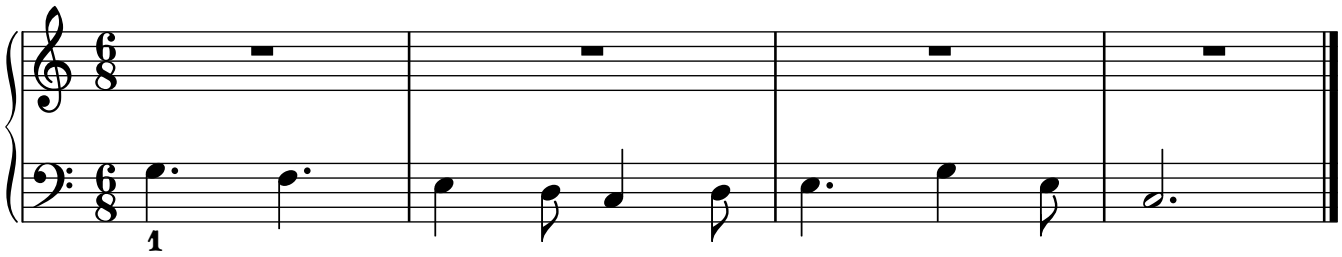
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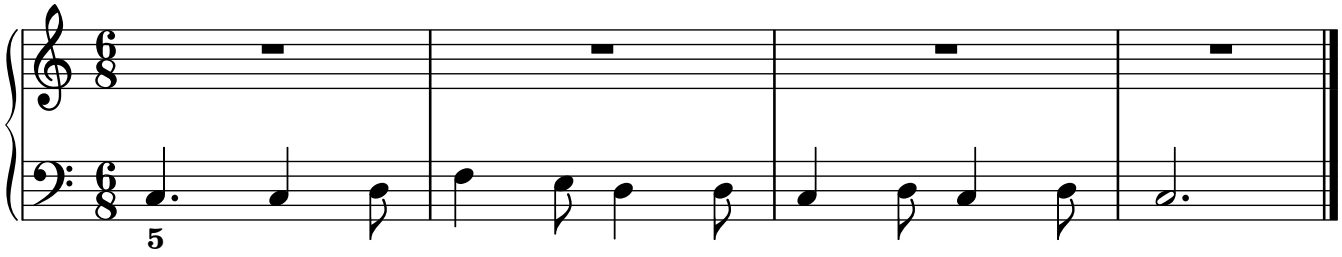
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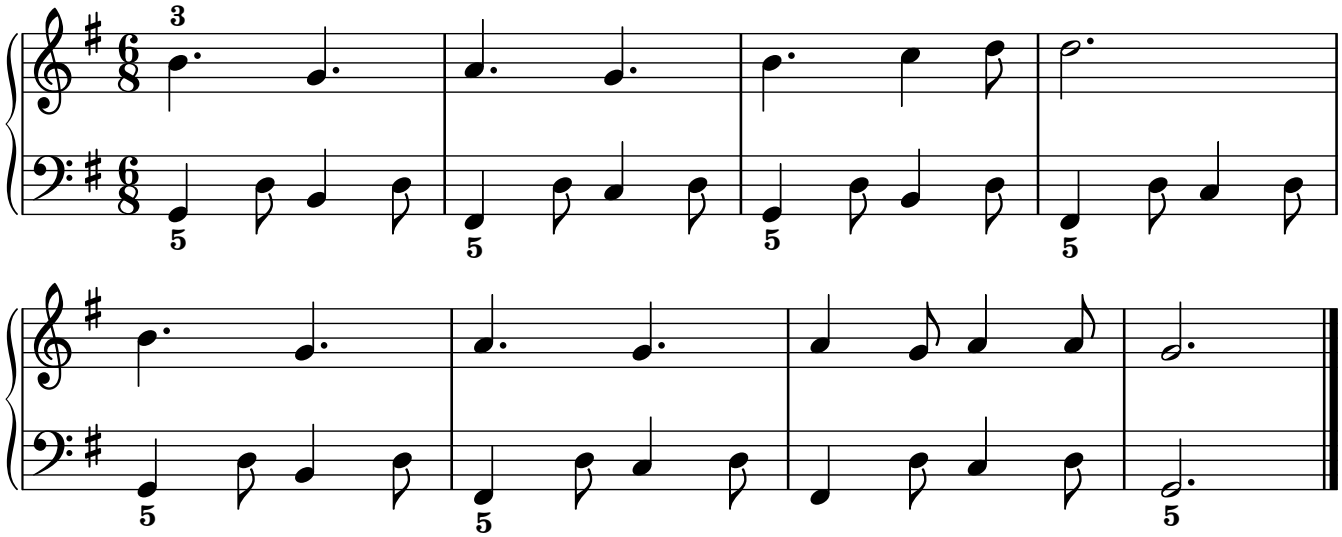


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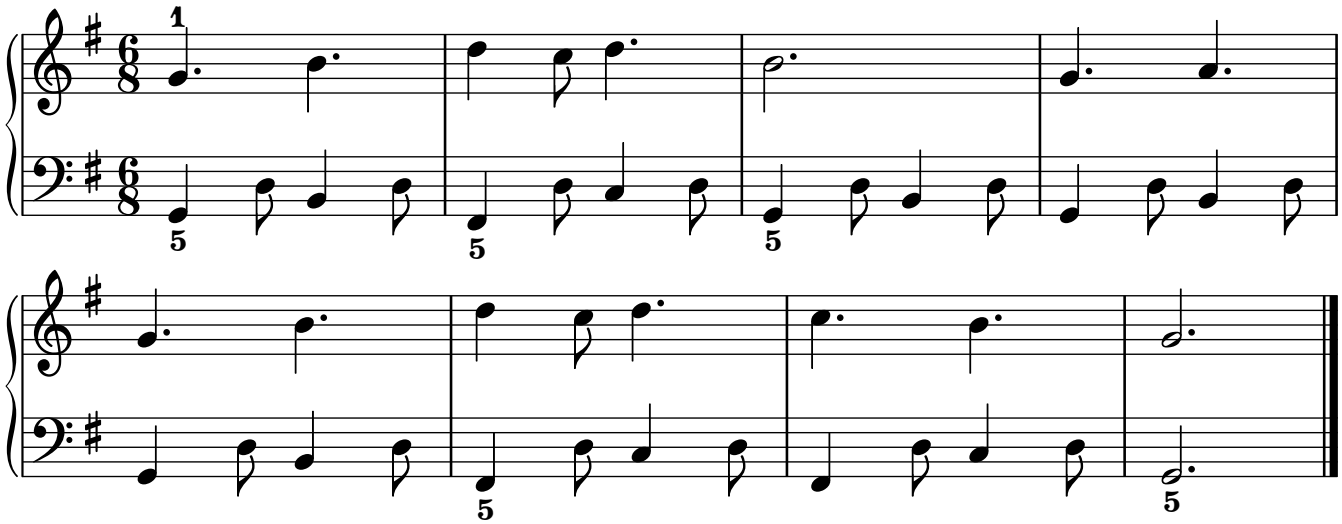


Part C: A lilting bass in G major ♩. = 50

G major, hands together. The left hand plays the lilting pattern: long, short, long, short.
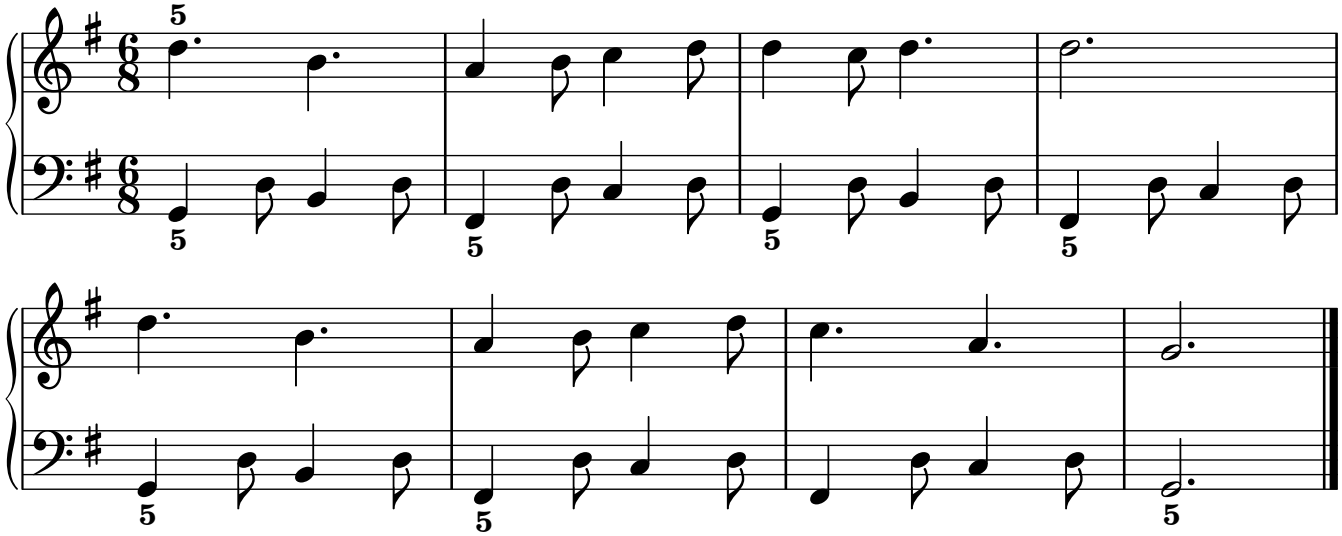
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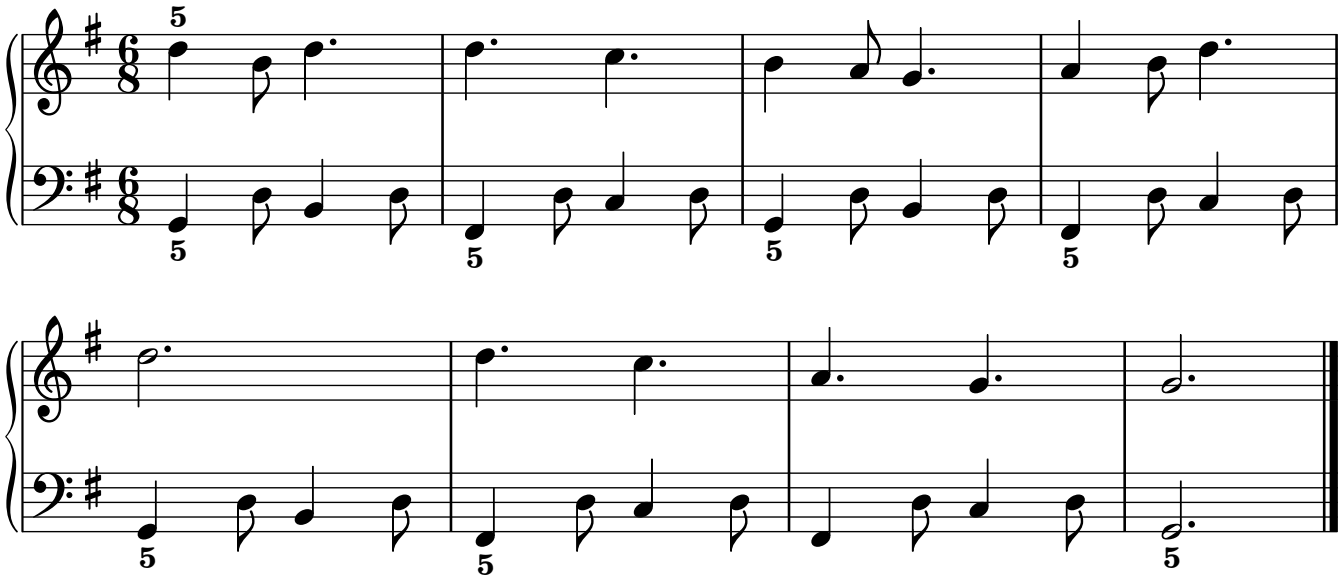


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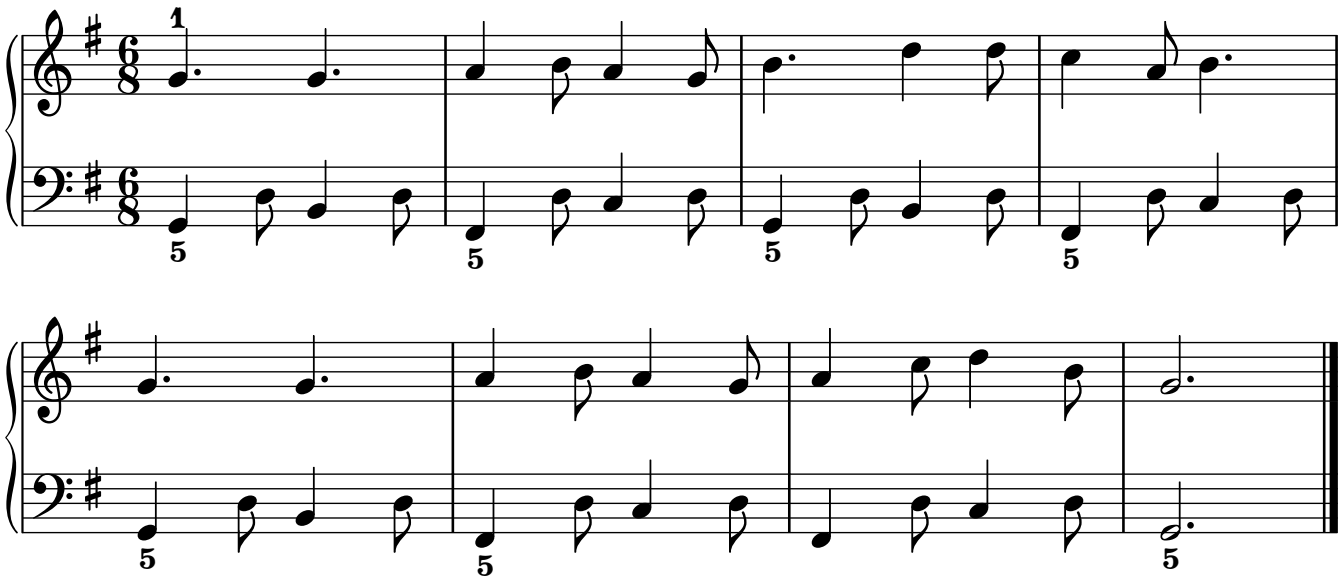


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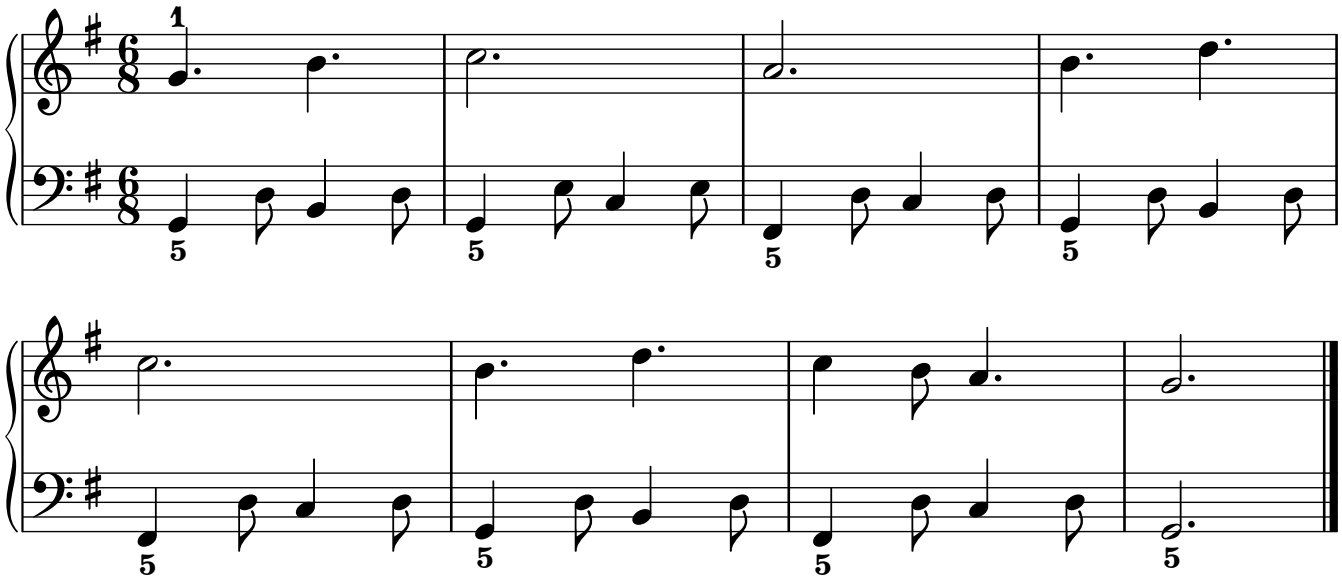


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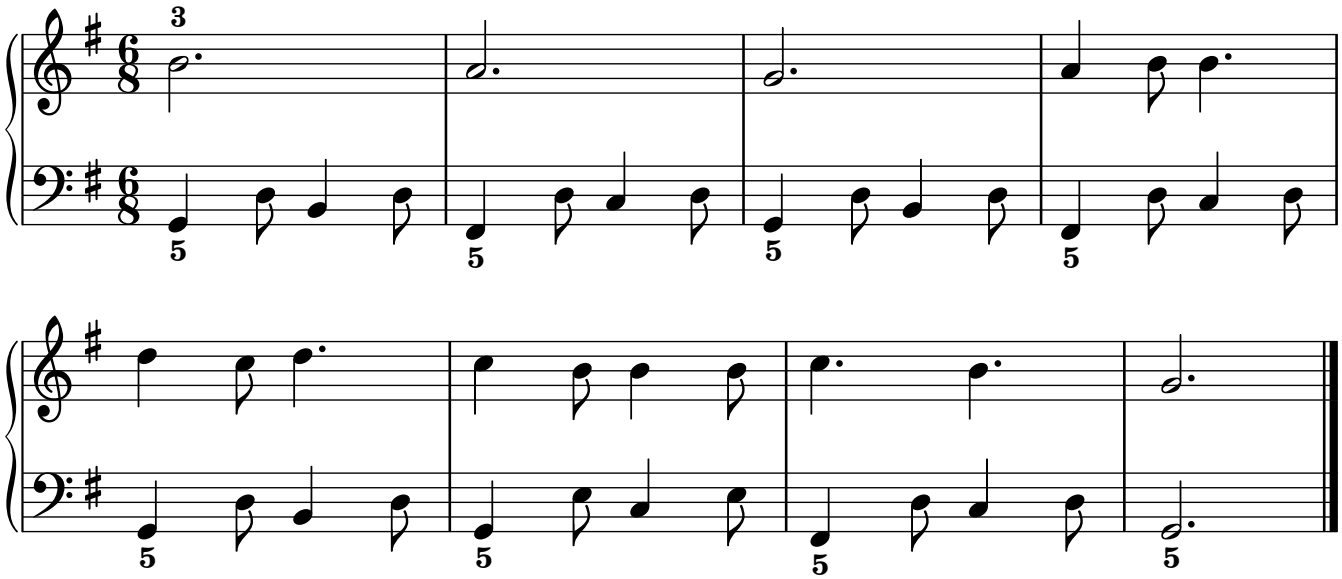


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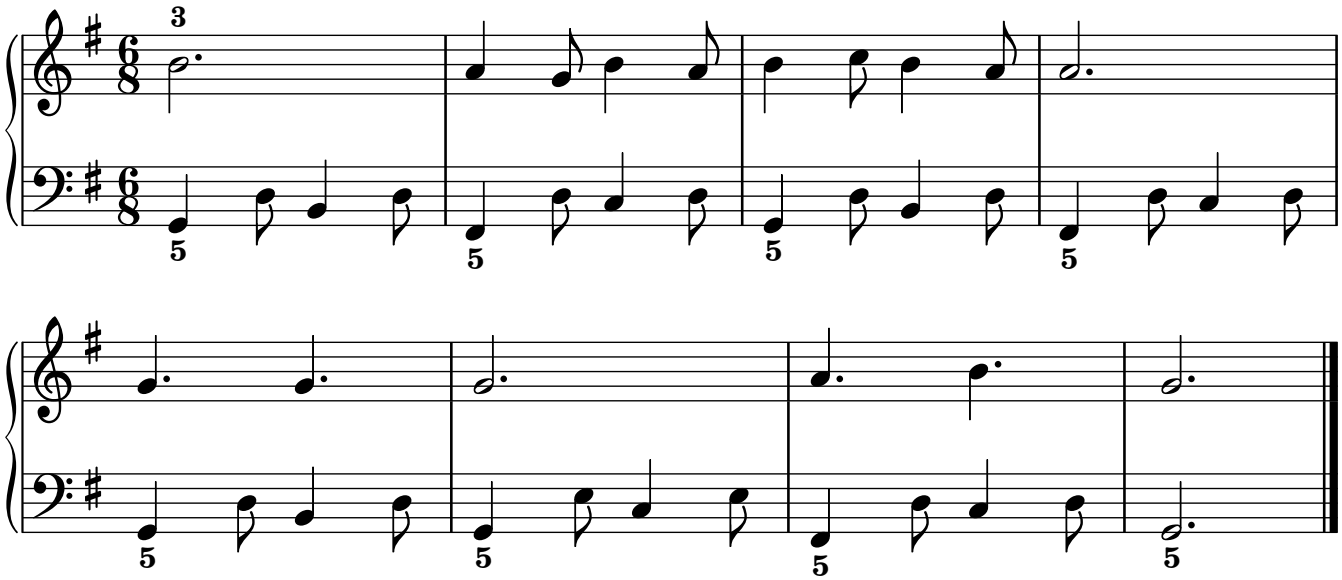


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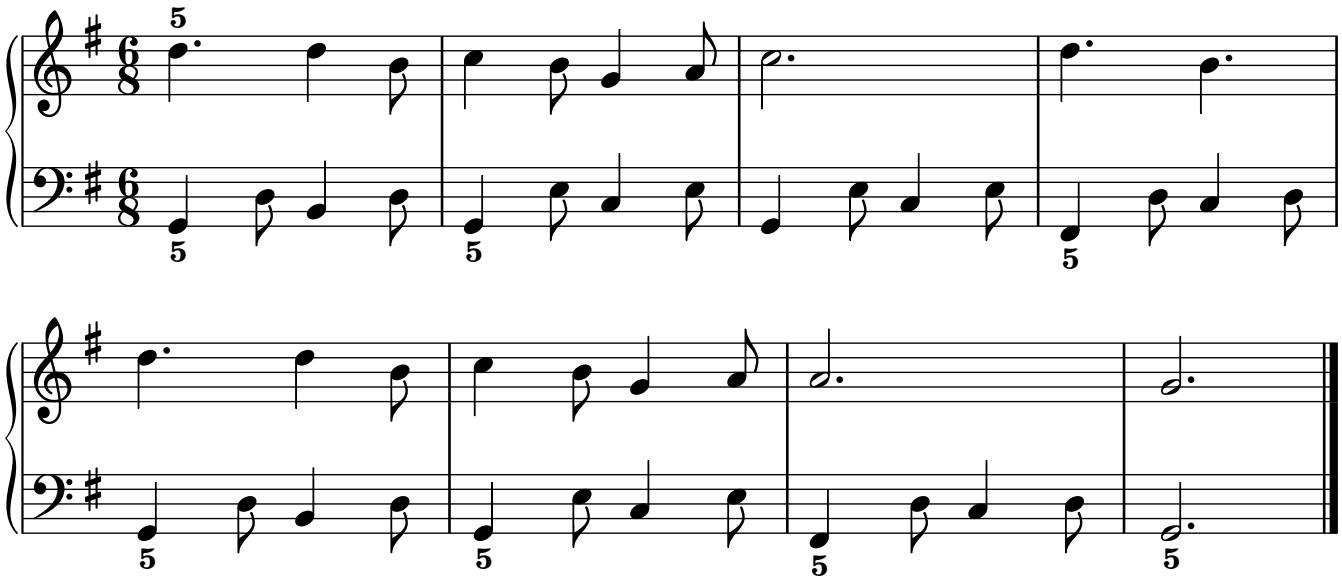
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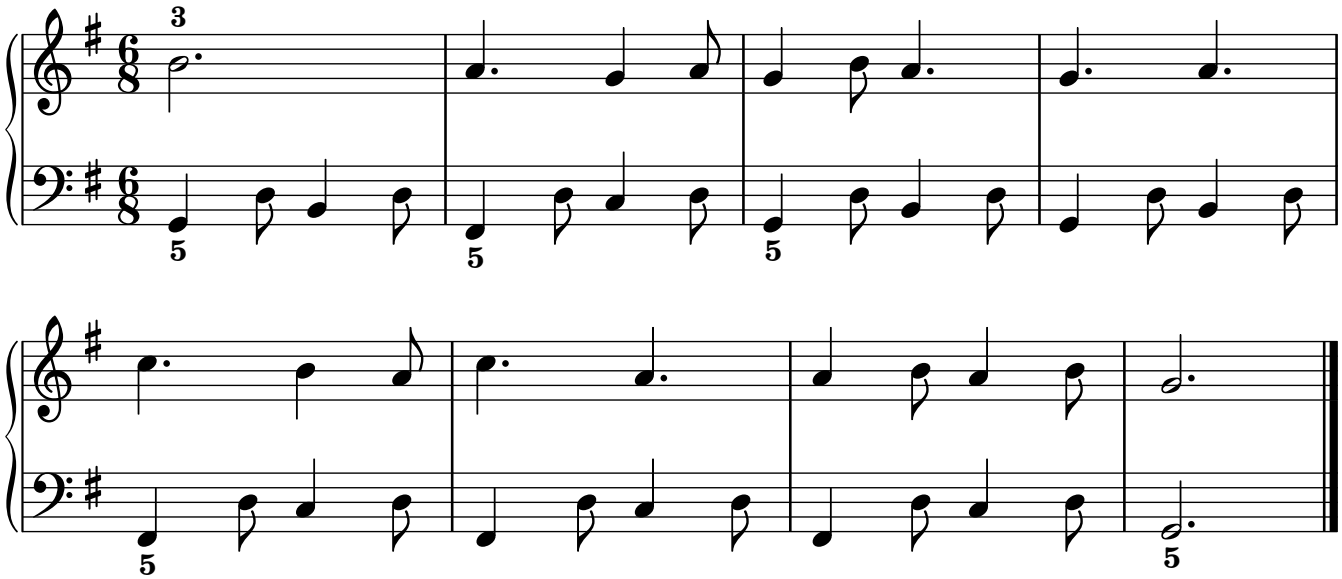


3.26



3.27



3.28

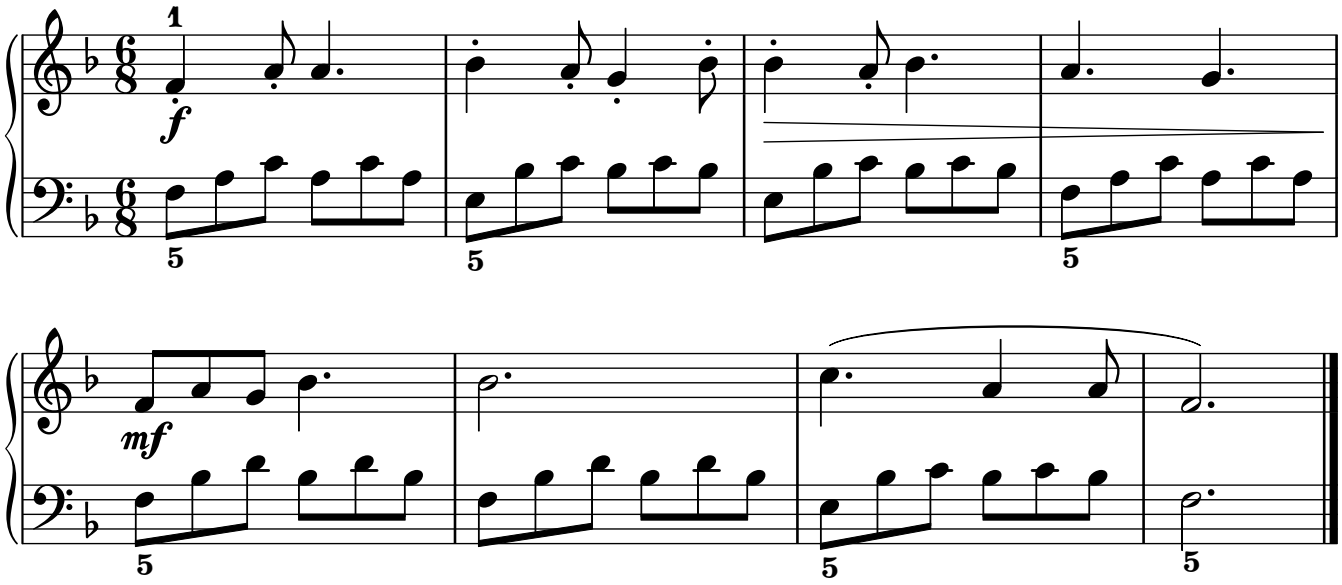


Part D: Rolling eighths in F major

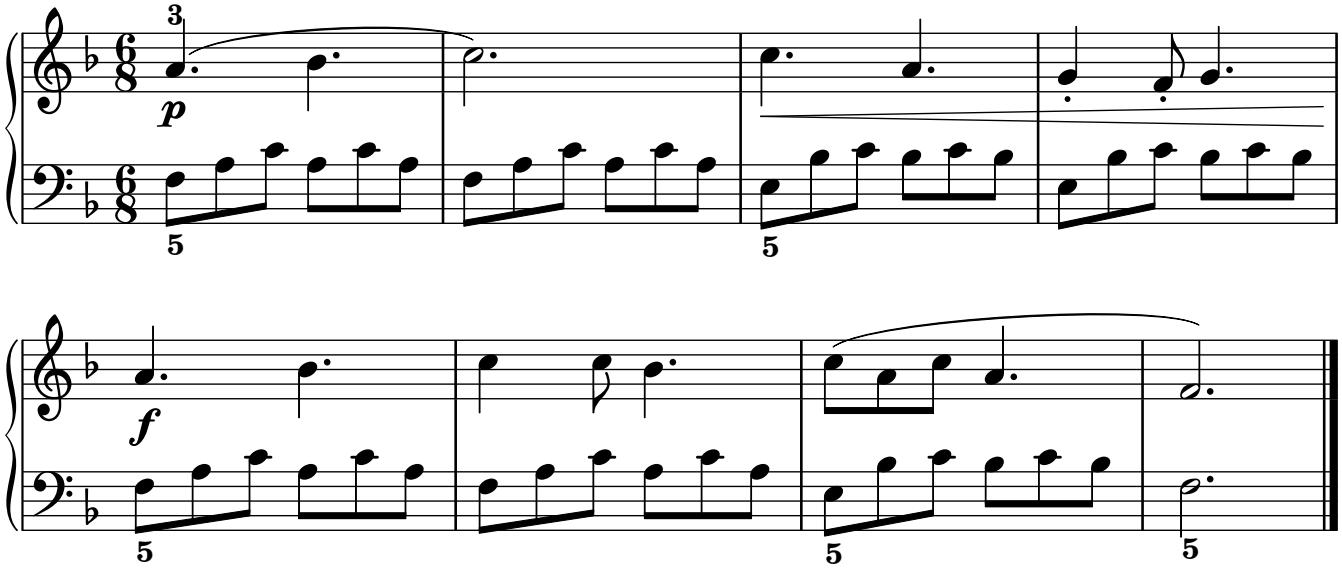
♩. = 46

F major with the rolling pattern: six even eighths in the left hand.

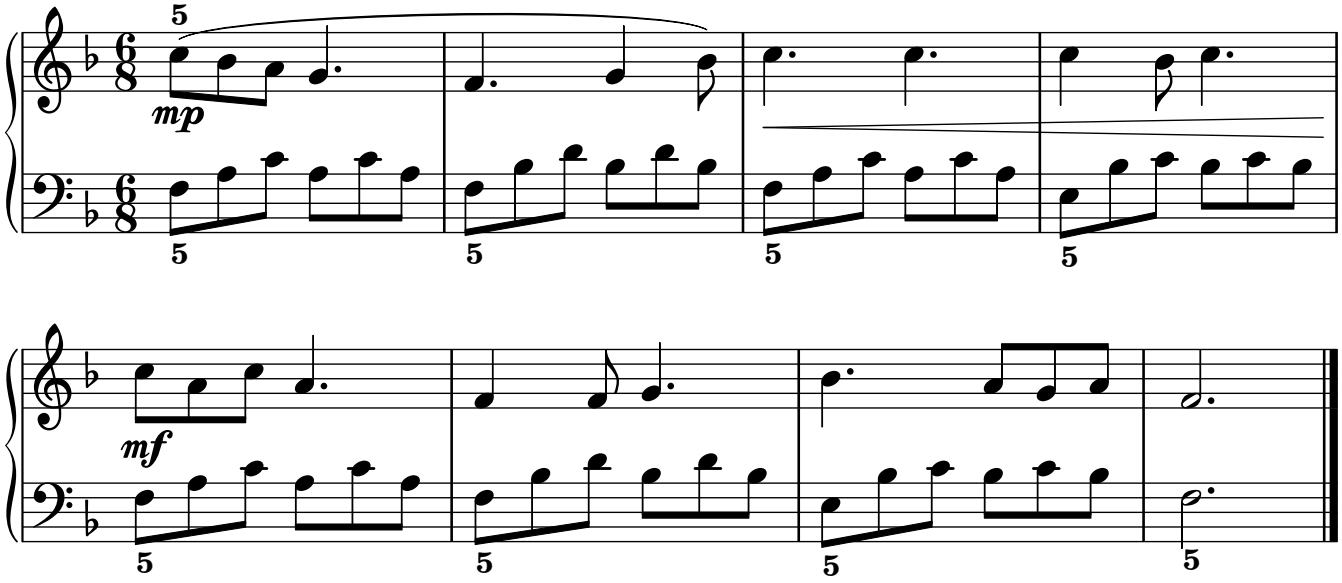
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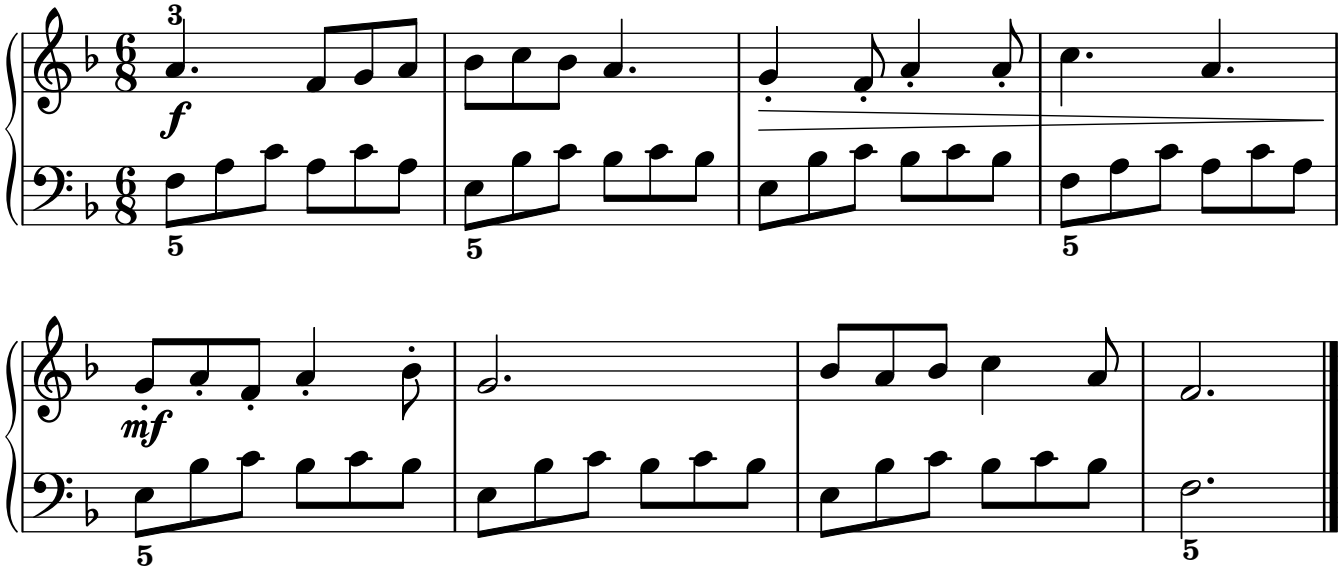


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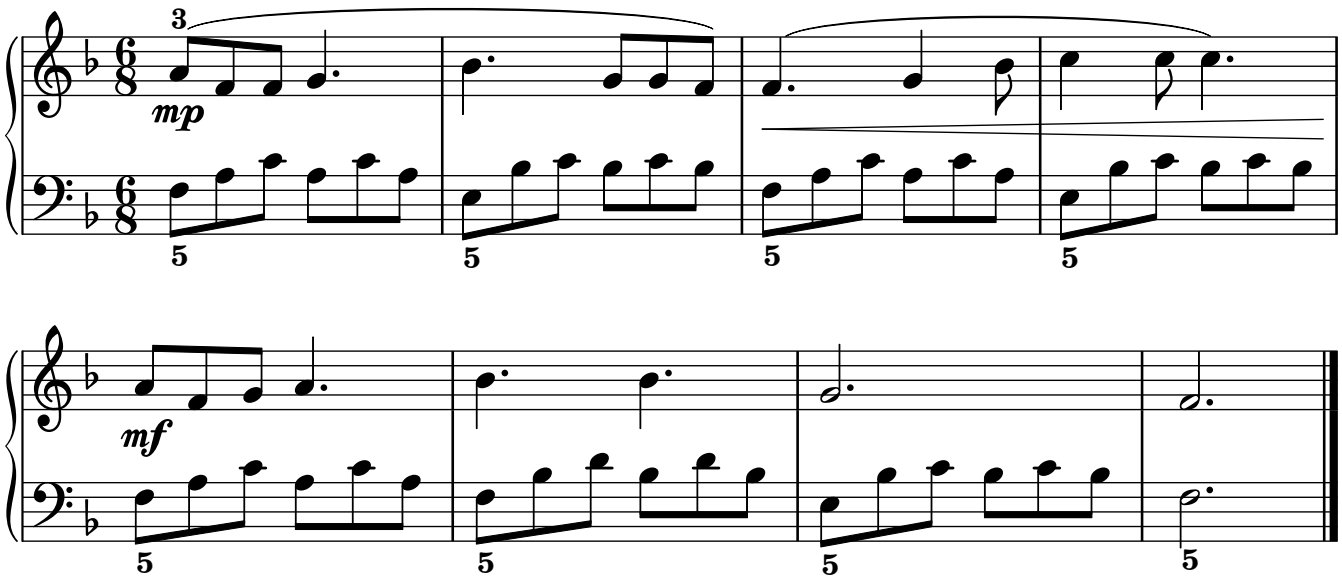


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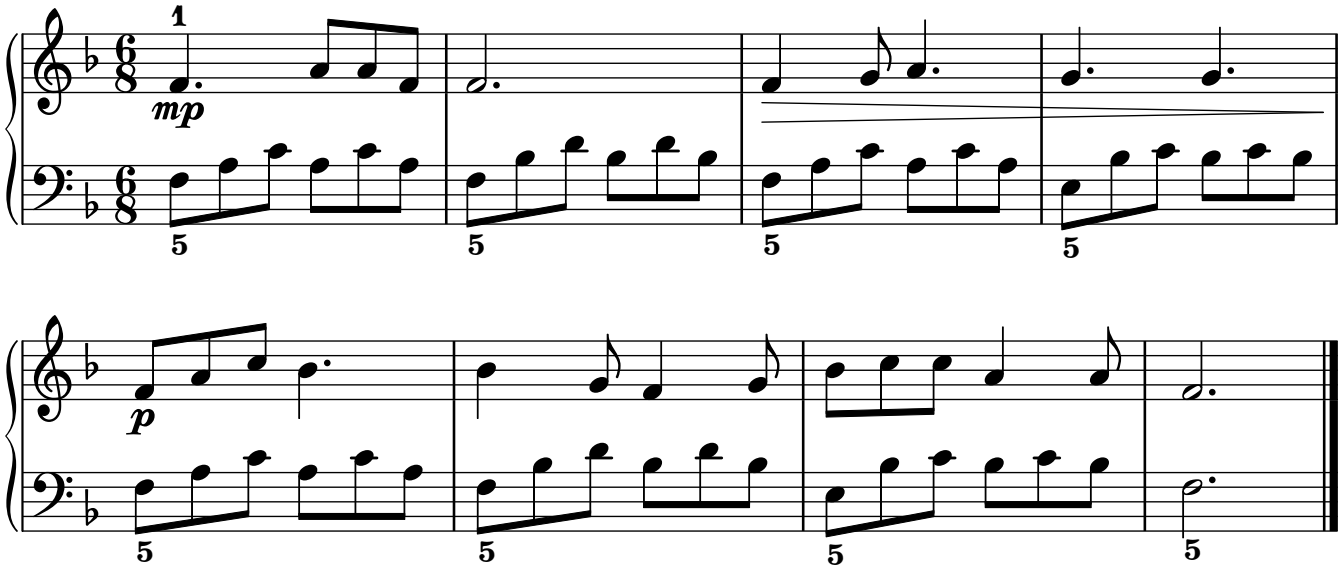


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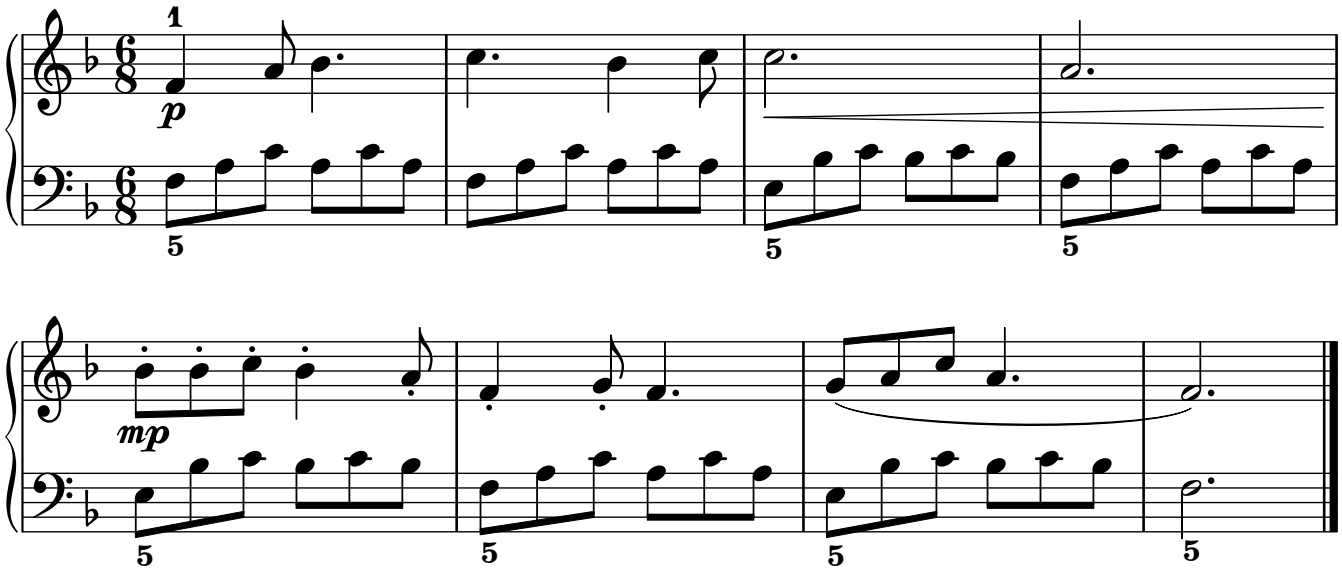
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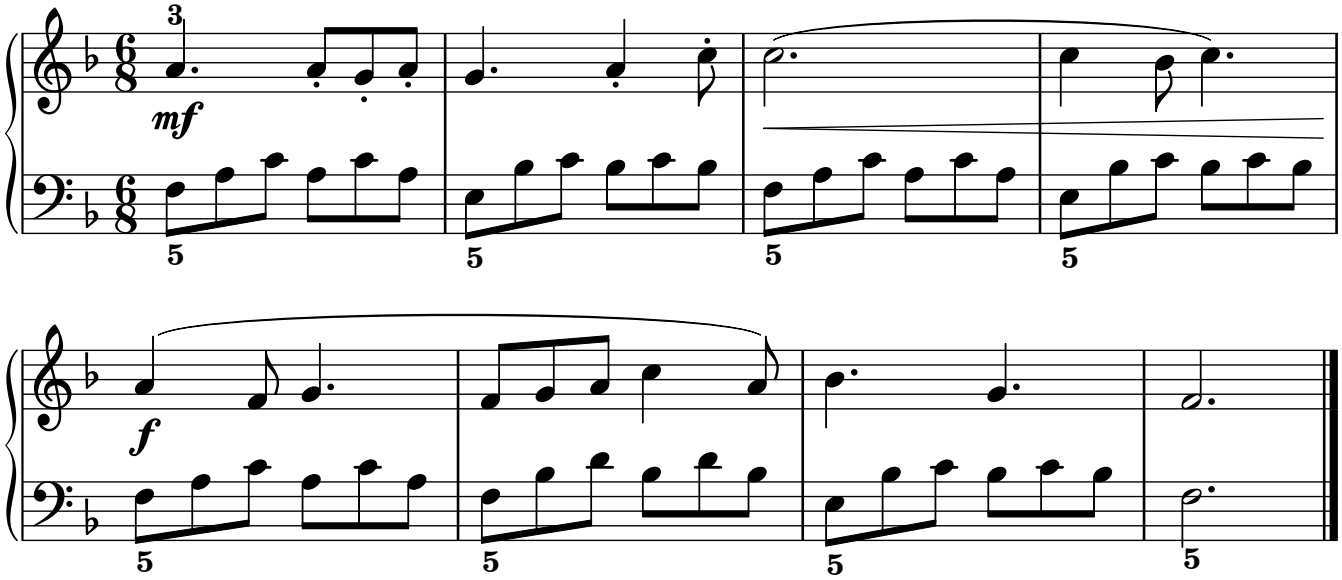


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3.35



3.36



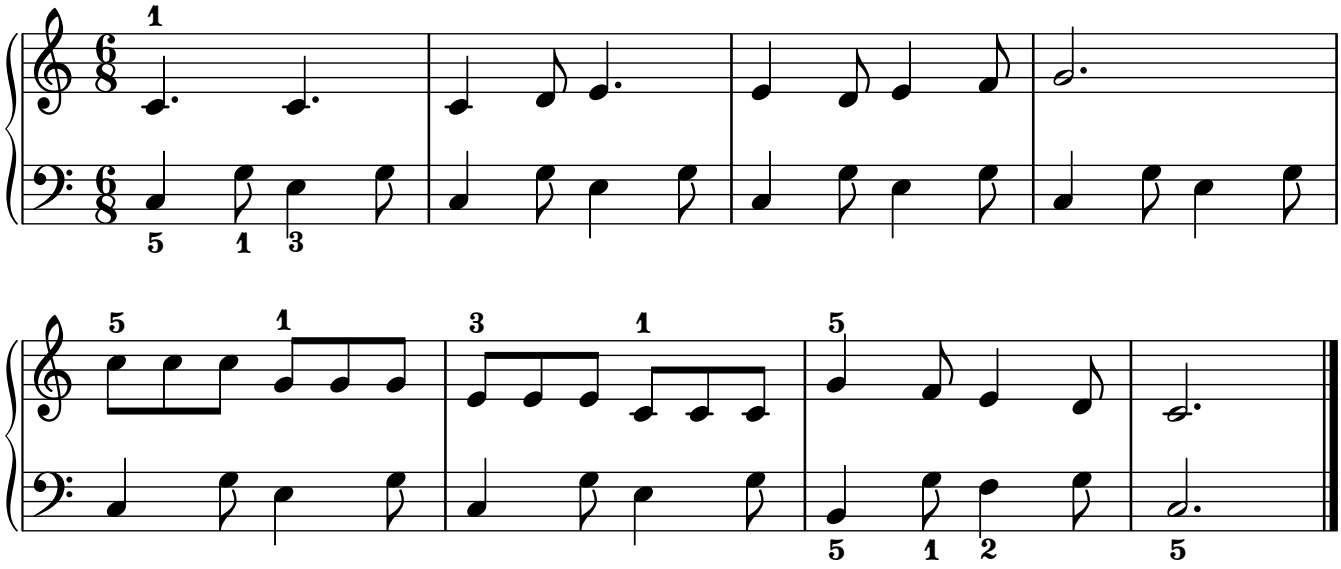
Pieces

Pieces are for playing more than once. Read each one first without stopping, like an exercise; then practise it until it sounds steady and musical.

Row, Row, Row Your Boat ♩. = 56

Traditional song (published 1852)
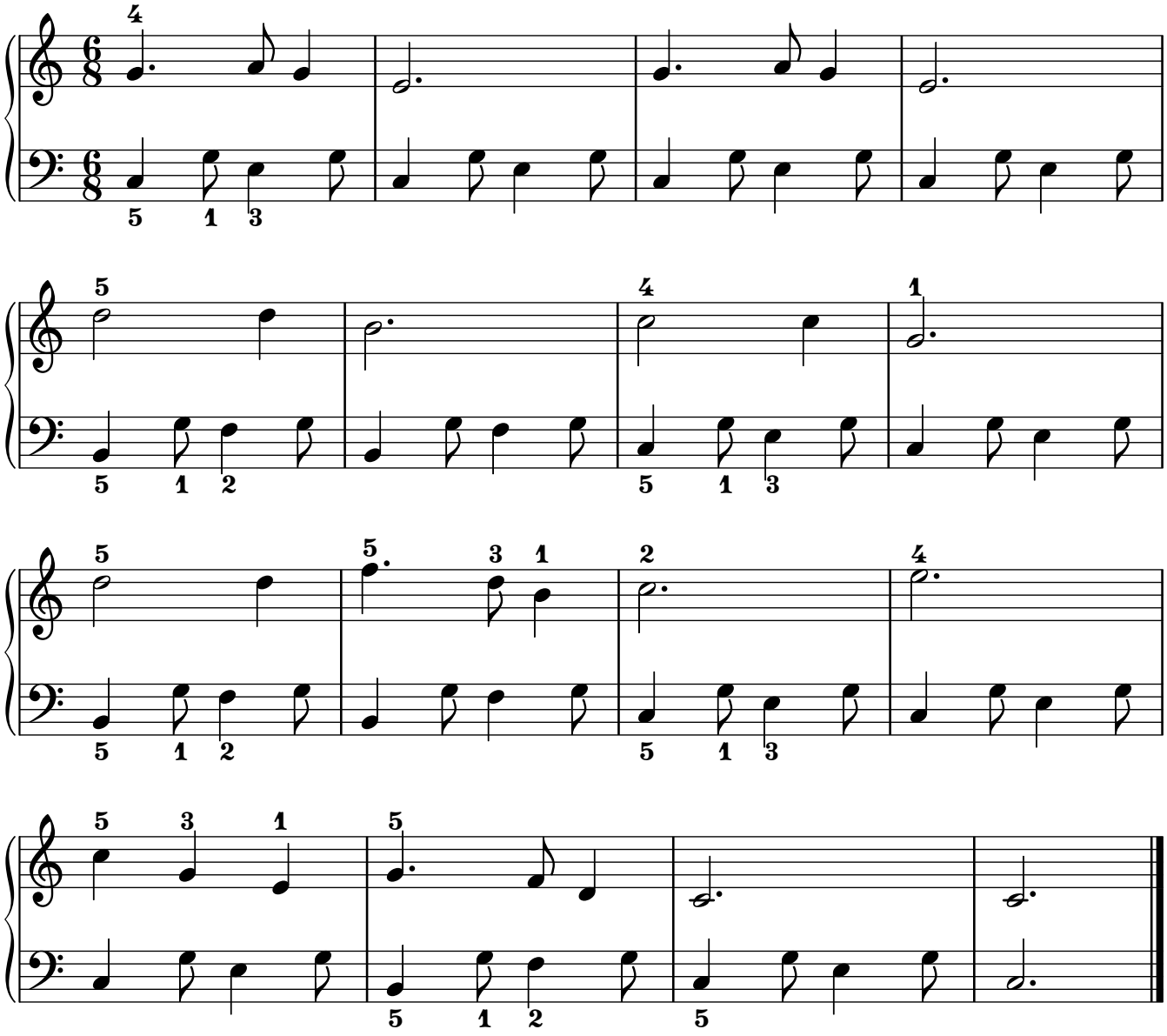
The best-known 6/8 song. In bar 5 the right hand moves up so finger 5 takes high C; in bar 6 it moves back to C position. The left hand lilts on I until the V7 in bar 7. It is also a round: two players can start two bars apart.



Silent Night ♩. = 44

Franz Xaver Gruber (1818) - shortened and simplified

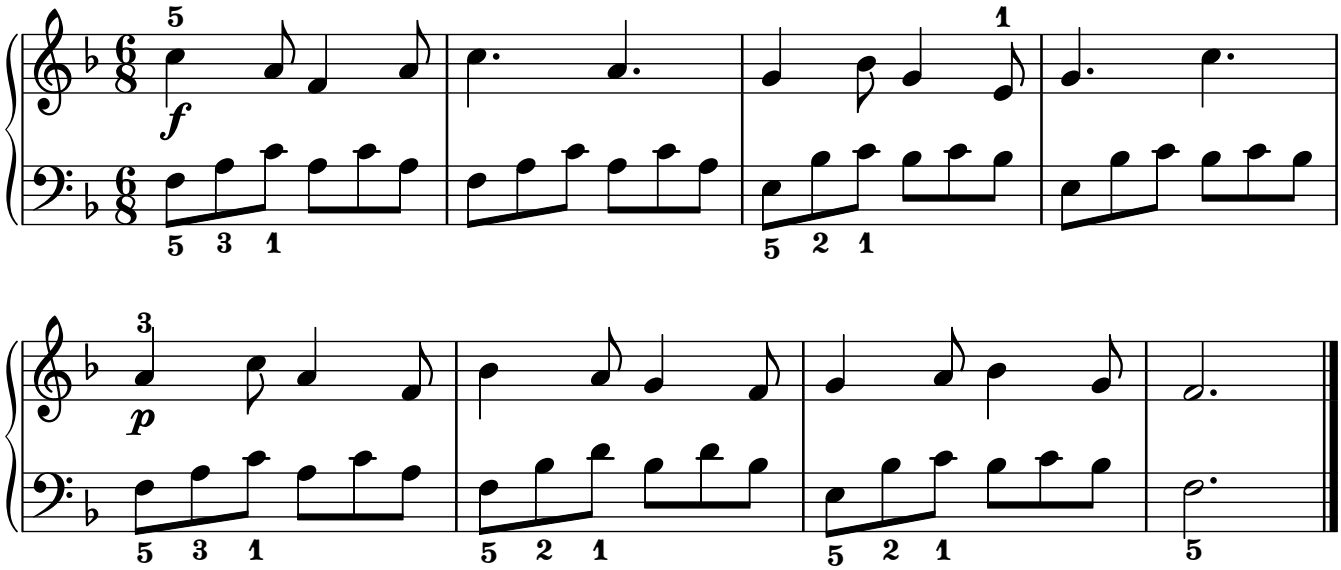
The first eight bars and the last eight bars of the carol. The tune climbs through three hand positions; the finger numbers show each move. The left hand lilts on I and V7.



Hunting Horns ♩. = 52

Original

Loud horn calls, then a soft echo. The left hand plays rolling eighths; in bars 3 and 4 the V7 shape has B-flat in the middle. In bar 3 the right hand stretches finger 1 down to E.



Checkpoint: ready for Unit 4?

- Play five new Part C or D exercises at the speeds shown: at most one stop each, 9 notes out of 10 right.
- You can feel two beats in each bar, and the long-short rhythm swings rather than sounding even.
- When you pass, move on to Unit 4.